



The Big Deal About Small Talk

"Don't knock the weather; nine-tenths of the people couldn't start a conversation if it didn't change once in a while."

—Kin Hubbard

Small talk is usually a prelude to a more serious business conversation later or it supplements the main activity or conversation you are pursuing. It is that shallow, informal and somewhat impersonal conversation which can last anywhere from a few minutes to a very long time. It is a part of the ice-breaking process, setting up the environment to be more conducive to serious business conversation.

Small talk is all around us, like oxygen in the atmosphere (see Snapshot 35.1 for some examples of small talk). Like oxygen, we feed on it and keep going through good days and bad days. Annoying at times, exhilarating and gratifying at other times, we alternately tolerate it and seek it. What is interesting is how it has crept into the world of business over the years and now holds an important place as a catalyst of business communication. A culture of healthy small talk is now being nurtured in

Snapshot 35.1

SMALL TALK IN THE OFFICE

1. You are on the phone with your client in the USA. Before all the serious conversation about migrating a database to another data centre, you ask him about

the weather in Colorado and tell him about how you saw footage of their snow, on TV in India. This gives a nice personal touch to the relationship.

2. You have a room full of visiting partners from Singapore. It is the first visit to India for many of them. The meeting is about to start in ten minutes. You have just finished exchanging business cards. You treat the cards with great care and use them as a cue to start small talk about where they are located in Singapore and how they get to work every day and so forth. You try to draw in everyone from their delegation into the conversation, just so that they all feel included and comfortable.
3. You are in your manager's office to discuss some important things about the project. Your gaze falls on his bookshelf and you see a book on statistics. That paves way for you to start small talk on how your uncle was a professor of statistics—setting a pleasant tone for a more serious and 'dry' discussion on schedules and activities.
4. You are at an office party. You know half the people very well. But there are many you don't know that well. You walk up to a small circle of people and join in. The conversation moves from topic to topic (and occasionally even to 'shop-talk') and you participate in it without being shy or awkward about it. In another corner, you see the CEO himself chit-chatting with a bunch of people and you walk up to him and manage to get a few words with him.

business communities the world over. This is also a part of the image make-over of the world of business, from being utterly serious, quiet places to being fun, expressive and animated environments.

And you can add even more circumstances where you indulge in small talk—a luncheon at a technical symposium where you hobnob with all the technical experts, a chance encounter on the street with a business partner, a 'pit-stop' at the administrative assistant's desk and so on. Almost no place is immune to small talk.

The ability to make small talk is no longer considered just social grace, but is seen to be an important business soft skill. While Indians are by no means bashful when it comes to speaking, the finesse and perfection of the art of small talk that is seen in the USA and the divide we see in this area between Indians and Americans, have convinced the authors to have a separate chapter to discuss what small talk is in context of today's business world and to look at its various attributes and scope.

Most of us only have a vague idea of what small talk is, or how it is different from other kinds of talk, how it can be used effectively and how we can be good at it. We don't even realize that small talk is no longer the simple-minded, impulsive act that it used to be, but has evolved into a highly engineered, painstakingly cultivated and skillfully delivered product. The purpose of this chapter is to highlight the importance of small talk as an important element of business etiquette to develop in your

soft skills armory, characterize what is and what is not small talk, give you some tips on how to use small talk effectively and suggest some typical small talk topics for the Indian/American work cultures.

It should be remembered, however, that small talk should not hijack your primary effort or draw attention away from your real activity. No action item comes out of small talk, unlike your main business conversation.

35.1 WHY SMALL TALK?

Here are some reasons why we need small talk in our offices.

- ▶ Small talk is a nice lead-in for a more serious business conversation.
- ▶ It helps the participants to settle down.
- ▶ Right at the outset, small talk conveys the message, 'I am a nice and friendly person. You will be happy to deal with me' and therefore, helps the rest of the transaction to go smoothly even if there are technical or business problems encountered along the way. Thus, it is a nice preamble for later technical sessions or business negotiations.
- ▶ You create a friendly, fun atmosphere to work in and transact business. You obviously don't want to work in an ambience that is grim and graveyard-like, where everyone is tense and tongue-tied.
- ▶ You can 'scope out' people and identify the friendly ones.
- ▶ You can network with people and strangers and build relationships.
- ▶ It helps you mingle socially. It breaks the ice with strangers.
- ▶ It makes it easy to navigate through rough spots, lightens up tense situations and can ease the 'customer-vendor' gap.
- ▶ Is a measure of hospitality displayed by the hosts

35.2 SOME CHARACTERISTICS OF SMALL TALK

The first and most important characteristic of small talk is that it is highly culture-dependent and its style and content can vary from country to country. In countries like the USA, small talk is practised almost to perfection. It is not uncommon there to see an end-customer carrying on a two-minute chit-chat with the checkout counter clerk in a store, while transacting business. Or for an air passenger to have a parallel small talk session with the airline employee about his mother-in-law in Chicago while checking in his luggage. Some other countries are more formal and less talkative—especially with strangers. But all cultures are now beginning to see the value of small talk and are actively encouraging it among their employees.

Small talk should be bright, fun, positive and light. And when a huge group indulges in it, it should bring out a variety of views, quips and points. Everyone participating in it should feel elated and good. Small talk can be about a variety of



Fig. 35.1

topics—as long as they are non-intrusive and neutral—we have listed some of them towards the end of the chapter. In our chapter on ‘privacy’ (Chapter 36) we have provided a list of topics that are absolutely inappropriate for small talk (from the privacy standpoint). In essence, small talk should lighten up the atmosphere around, so that it facilitates actual business discussions.

Small talk should be an exercise in building chemistry among the participants. For example, if your colleague says, ‘I am going to Delhi tomorrow to see my brother’, you may ask, ‘What does your brother do in Delhi?’ and carry forward the conversation. Your response is more out of courtesy than out of a desire to get to know your colleague, or his brother, for that matter. (If on the other hand your colleague says ‘I am going to Delhi on a personal visit’, it is definitely inappropriate to ask ‘What are you going to Delhi for?’) Small talk is usually fuelled by a desire to build rapport, rather than by a desire to get to know the personal details of the other person. It is very unobtrusive and the other participants do not expect to field any personal questions. And therefore, it creates a relaxed and friendly atmosphere for everyone.

During small talk, you can move from topic to topic and the number of people participating in it can vary (often people go in and out of a group). This is typically the case during the waiting time before the start of a meeting (when some people come late).

Small talk has a staccato-like structure, with people adding their own comments, anecdotes and points to the conversation in a piece-meal fashion, punctuated with a lot of jokes and mild digs. Since people you don’t know at all may be participating in it, the conversation should provide enough openings and comfort level for them. And also because the conversation is fragmented, it can end any time without anything going amiss.

The content of small talk should be genuine—you don’t lie that your mother-in-law is in Chicago and nor do you spread cooked-up stories to keep the conversation going.

35.3 WHAT IS NOT SMALL TALK?

Small talk is not the same as technical talk. If anything, they are opposites. Occasionally in the middle of small talk, you may migrate to some technical conversation and shop-talk, as appropriate. But keep the two separate. Small talk or tech talk, you should be an expert in both and be able to don both the hats effortlessly.

It is not the big talk or the 'regular' conversation you have with your trusted friends and colleagues in your office. When you have personal conversations with your friends, you are not on your guard. Whereas, in office small talk (like in office technical talks), you are careful about what you say and measure your comments.

It is not personal conversation, no matter how many times the other person talks about his mother-in-law in Chicago. Don't for a moment assume that you have become great personal friends with the other person, based only on the history of small talk you had with him, unless the other parameters check out.

Small talk is not a sales talk. Sales talk has an agenda and an underlying motive. Small talk has no such driving force or pressure. It is not cooked up and dished out only to persuade the other person through a business transaction that would otherwise fall through and after which you go back to your old ways after the transaction. The personality you display while engaging in small talk is your real personality.

And lastly, small talk has a place and a purpose in corporate life. If done appropriately, it is neither unnecessary, nor a waste of time.

35.4 SOME SMALL TALK CONSIDERATIONS

When to Engage in Small Talk

Practically any time is a good time for small talk. Just before meetings or just after meetings are ideal times to unleash your small-talk talents. Company events like picnics, visits, canteen sessions, running into someone in the hallway, conferences and so on are convenient situations for small talk. It is somewhat expected in non-emergency phone calls. A one line 'small-talk' comment or question in an e-mail is also appropriate.

Of course, before starting a bout of small talk, determine if the other person is in a mood for it. It is most inappropriate to make small talk when no one is in a mood for it or when you are in the middle of a serious discussion.

How Small Should It Be?

As the name implies, it better be shallow and general. The topic should generate comments that are innocuous and inoffensive. Be sure nothing you say is controversial or is a transgression. Also make sure that you are not boring or irritating. Watch out for others' reaction towards you—they will switch you off if your small talk doesn't cut it. If an untenable situation arises, just make some excuses and end the session.

You can enter into small talk anytime and can also exit any time. But if a talk is already in progress, make sure you don't throw its flow off by your untimely remarks.

Since small talk is ephemeral, you have to make sure that your comments follow the flow and are in synch with the rest of the conversation. Be alert to how quickly the topic changes and takes different flavours.

You can occasionally stick in a short serious question in a small talk situation. If you see that your boss has sufficiently loosened up after a nice dinner and is engaged in a session of small talk, you might ask him a serious question in the middle of it. ('I wonder what it will take for me to be on the Citibank project.') But don't embarrass the other person by dwelling on it.

Who Do You Have Small Talk With?

You can have small talk with anyone—your colleagues, your managers, your business partners, your canteen workers and even with total strangers. You will have to acquire a slightly extroverted personality and a smiling face and somewhat of an aggressive demeanour.

In a large gathering, such as in your office party, make sure you take on the avatar of a social butterfly and flutter from group to group. This is a golden opportunity to snare your otherwise elusive office bigwigs. Making small talk with the introverted and the language-challenged can be frustrating, but is important and necessary. Draw them into the conversation somehow. Don't just stick to the talkative. One of the objectives of small talk is to mingle and get to rapport with the other person—all of them.

Small talk is also extremely socialistic—in the sense that all are equal, in spite of rank and seniority. It integrates everyone, whether someone is your customer or vendor, whether the other person is in your organization or elsewhere.

35.5 HOW TO BE EFFECTIVE IN SMALL TALK?

Like we have mentioned earlier, you should acquire an extroverted personality and get rid of any shyness that you may have. This comes only with practice. Remember that through your small-talk skills, you are projecting a certain poise, confidence and smartness. Remember too that all your communication skills like body language, listening skills and so on, apply here too.

Since the effectiveness of small talk depends on the interest levels of the topic of small talk, you better choose topics that are current and engrossing to people around you. This calls for a very informal audience analysis and knowing their pulse as to what excites them. This also requires that you be aware of the most topical issues to engage in small talk. This may require you to be an avid follower of current events or at least to glance at the newspaper to know the major happenings around you.

Until you become somewhat of an expert in the matter, stick to some standard topics. Also, in the beginning stages of your small talk career, stick to smaller groups where you can be more comfortable, instead of trying to nucleate a new group. If you cannot come up with a good topic, 'you' be the topic and narrate one of your anecdotes. Try to come across as genuine, amusing people with tales of your own mistakes and mis-steps.

Take the initiative. It is not out of character to walk up to a strange person in a business setting and start a conversation. There are standard ice-breaking topics—your company, the weather, the state of your favourite cricket (or football) team. As mentioned earlier, business-card exchange itself can be a nice setting for a lot of initial small talk, not to mention the flood of topics that are available if the other person is from a different country. Don't abruptly leave a person or a group to go elsewhere—be courteous enough to smile and say a 'please excuse me' before you split from the group.

At no time should you come across as a slick salesman or investigator who is plumbing for information. Avoid probing questions. Instead prompt the other person to talk. If one topic gets stalled, try to launch another topic.

If you are already a good small talker, be inclusive of everyone. Make sure that it is an open forum and does not degenerate into a clubby, exclusive group chatter. Ask others questions and drag them into the conversation. Try to steer the talk and close gaps in conversation. Likewise, watch out for any potential controversies or embarrassments or potential conflicts and nip them in the bud or make a joke out of them.

Remember that as an effective small talker, you just have to conduct the conversation and engage the participants. You don't have to be the main speaker and overwhelm the other person (unless you are a superior or a boss—in which case, your underlings will naturally show deference to you and let you do most of the talking. As a corollary—the more you go up in your career ladder, the more you should be prepared to engage in small talk).

Also, remember that people expect you to be good in both small talk and serious technical discussions. So, you should be ready to switch back and forth between these two modes of talk. Make points and comments that others will find interesting. Long after the conversation, people should remember you for your views and comments.

Remember that even if you are not a great talker, you can participate in small talk very effectively by being a good and active listener. Just know when to laugh, respond, comment and interject.

35.6 WHAT ARE GOOD TOPICS FOR SMALL TALK?

Often 'you' will be the subject of your small talk and you will find yourself coming with your anecdotes or your viewpoints. In which case, bring something to the table—either an exciting hobby or stories of some places you have travelled to or some interesting things that happened to you. But don't make this an incredibly boring autobiographical note of your childhood or your heroic efforts in solving a serious problem in your previous job. Small talk is not the time to brag about yourself, nor is it a forum to moan about the not-so-good things in life.

Apart from these, here is a short list of topics to have small talk on:

- ▶ Matters of taste, preference (e.g., restaurants)
- ▶ Traffic, cars
- ▶ Weekend activities

- ▶ Activities around the house (gardening, kitchen re-modelling)
- ▶ Vacation stories
- ▶ Books you have read, movies, TV shows
- ▶ Sports events (but remember that most American don't know or care for cricket)
- ▶ Relatives (but don't dwell on this too much as the other party is sure to become disinterested very soon)
- ▶ Shopping activities and experience
- ▶ Children, school (be sure that others around also show interest)
- ▶ Doctor/dentist visits—just the non-medical part
- ▶ World events (avoid controversial and sensitive topics, especially things like the state of Indo-US relations, nuclear deals and so on)
- ▶ New purchases, gadgets
- ▶ Hometown, childhood anecdotes
- ▶ On-the-job experiences and how life used to be in the organization
- ▶ Non-malicious stories about other people present and past (but no company politics)
- ▶ Pets (definitely a common small talk topic in the USA, but very uncommon in a typical Indian middle-class household)
- ▶ Weddings, parties.

As you can see, there is a significant cultural and personal component in these topics. For example, sports can be a neutral and fun topic for small talk. But there is hardly any common ground between Indians and Americans in sports. Typical American sports like professional basketball, baseball and American football have virtually no following in India and similarly, there is no following of world cricket or even tennis and the USA.

The challenge then is to choose topics with which you are familiar (at least superficially) and that are likely to be of common interest. As mentioned earlier, this will come only with practice and by keeping current with various events and goings on. Now is as good a time as any to start this practice and hone your small talk etiquette.

35.7 IN SUMMARY

It is somewhat interesting that something as remote to business as small talk is now actually considered a strong business soft skill and held in high value. Like all other soft skills, you have to groom yourself in this as well. More than business degrees and experiences, the amount of networking and connections you make via small talk can contribute to your successful career. However, remember that the ability to make small talk should be in addition to all your other competencies—small talk by itself will not make you successful. Like any other soft skills, it is not a replacement for hard skills in your job. It is just the veneer.